

Amazon Fire TV Stick 4K Select

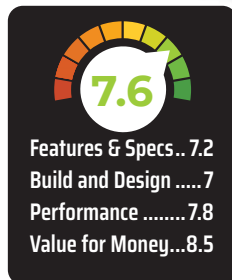
A lean but healthy offering with only the essentials

Amazon's streaming sticks have been Android-based for years, but the experience has shifted bit by bit. The new Fire TV Stick 4K Select is the first to move to Amazon's Linux-based Vega OS, marking a clear break from the older software. It also lands in the middle of the lineup, above the basic HD-only Fire TV Stick and below the Fire TV Stick 4K Plus. It gets you 4K and HDR support at Rs 3,999 (launch price: Rs 5,499). But the company has cut some corners to reach this price. Still, when Amazon sent over a unit, I was intrigued and excited to see what had actually changed in both hardware and software, and whether any of it mattered for someone looking to buy a new streaming stick. You can read my findings in the 4K Select review below.

The Amazon Fire TV Stick 4K Select is the cheapest and most practical way to get 4K HDR streaming in Amazon's product lineup. It delivers fine performance and meaningful upgrades over the entry model, but does not try to be the fastest or most premium stick, and that is fine. Those who need wider app flexibility or more advanced features should note that these remain limited on the 4K Select. But if all you want is reliable 4K streaming without spending extra, this is the sweet spot.

CONNECTIVITY AND REMOTE

If you've ever seen a Fire TV Stick before, the Fire TV Stick 4K Select will look quite familiar. It features a small black rectangle that plugs into an HDMI port



and draws power from an included micro-USB cable. Yes, that port is a little dated for today, but unless you lose the bundled cable, you should be fine. So, nothing fancy; just a compact and portable stick that stays hidden behind the TV

when in use. Only the charging cable comes out from behind the TV. And if you take the Stick with you somewhere, ensure you carry the cable as well. As part of the package, you get the Fire TV Stick 4K Select, a remote, two AAA batteries, a quick guide, the micro-USB cable, and an HDMI extender in case the HDMI port behind the TV isn't easily accessible. As per the Amazon support page, the 4K Select supports HDMI 2.1 output along with HDCP version 2.3. This means it is compatible

with modern TVs, and you can expect the highest quality streaming from services like Prime Video and Netflix without restrictions.

Finally, coming to the remote, it is a standard Alexa Voice Remote. You get the usual navigation ring, volume controls, mute, app shortcuts, and a built-in microphone. It feels light but not flimsy. The buttons have a soft click, which I prefer during late-night viewing. But there is no backlight, so you will end up memorising the layout or reaching for some ambient light in the dark.

SET UP AND SOFTWARE

Setting up the Amazon Fire TV Stick 4K Select is simple. You plug in the stick, connect to Wi-Fi, sign in to your Amazon account, and wait for updates. You can scan a QR code for a quicker log-in. And when the device boots into the home screen, you get a similar layout to other Fire TV streamers. Rows of apps and recommendations from different services beneath a banner ad for promoted content. If you have used any Fire TV device, you will adapt quickly.

Alexa works as expected. You press and hold the mic button, ask for a show, adjust the volume, or open apps. Voice search pulls results from multiple services, though it still prioritises Amazon content in the ranking.

App support is fine for regular users. Netflix, Prime Video, YouTube, JioHotstar, Sony Liv, and the rest are here. There are some pre-installed apps like Amazon Kids+, Amazon Music, Prime Video, Zee5, and Fox News. You can uninstall most of these. You also get out-of-the-box support for Equipment Control and Home Control of connected Amazon devices through Fire TV, with voice commands.

When it comes to voice searches, Fire TV is faster and more direct, especially for apps and film titles, but the results are not always accurate. Google TV is slower and more verbose, yet more reliable when you want the exact song or content match. For broad recommenda-